the great things about America is how smoothly we transfer presidential power, but after having lived in the White House, and having left it, I can understand how sad it must have been for Jimmy and Rosalynn Carter that day.

For the first time, the inauguration was being held on the west side of the Capitol. When we arrived, tens of thousands of people were already waiting on the Capitol grounds and streaming down the Mall in a great river of humanity. Flags and bunting were everywhere. In the distance above the people was the glittering white column of the Washington Monument and, beyond it, at the far end of the Mall, the Lincoln Memorial sparkled under the overcast sky like a beautiful diamond. Off to one side I could see the soft white dome of the Jefferson Memorial.

Those monuments, all those people—it was an unforgettable sight.

George Bush was sworn in as vice president and then it was my turn. As I took my place, the sun burst through the clouds in an explosion of warmth and light. I felt its heat on my face as I took the oath of office with my hand on my mother's Bible opened to the seventh chapter, fourteenth verse of Second Chronicles: "If my people, which are called by my name, shall humble themselves, and pray, and seek my face, and turn from their wicked ways; then will I hear from heaven, and will forgive their sin, and will heal their land."

Next to these words my mother—God rest her soul—had written: "A most wonderful verse for the healing of the nations."

Because it was on the minds of so many Americans, I devoted a good deal of my inaugural address to the state of our economy:

> The economic ills we suffer have come upon us over several decades. They will not go away in days, weeks